concentrate their efforts on utterly crushing their remaining enemy, the Chalukyas, so that by the time Narasimhavarman's great-grandson and namesake Narasimhavarman II had ascended the throne in 700 CE the Pallavas were once again the unchallenged power in the South.

Known popularly as Rajasimha, the 'Lion King', Narasimhavarman II was as ardent a follower of Lord Shiva as his forefathers – and he now had the peace and the prosperity to direct his devotion into temple-building, beginning with Kanchipuram's modest little Kailasanatha temple, undoubtedly one of the earliest stone-built (as opposed to carved out of stone) Hindu temples in Tamil country, although some would argue that the famous breaker-lapped 'Shore temple' on the coast south of Chennai at Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram) is older and that it, along with the little cluster of rock-cut *rathas* nearby, was actually begun by Rajasimha's great-grandfather Mahendravarma I.

The latter was popularly known as Mamallaballa, 'the great wrestler', on account of his martial prowess, and this is said to have given that area its local name of Mamallapuram. The British knew of the sculpted *rathas* as the 'Seven Pagodas'. They were the very first temples I explored on my first visit to South India in the late 1960s, and their very simplicity and scale left a lasting impression, so much so that for many years I found myself quite unable to appreciate the majesty of the vast temple cities of the South that evolved from here by way of Rajasimha's temples at Kanchipuram. I now better understand why it was that Kanchipuram came to be listed as one of India's seven sacred cities and why it came to be known as 'the Varanasi of the south'.

Yet even as Hinduism came into its own, Buddhism clung on – but only in isolated patches, and with only limited royal patronage. Centuries later, in 1820, a British missionary